

Is NT Textual Criticism a Science?

Have you ever heard or read (or said) the phrase, ‘the science of NT textual criticism’? How about the phrase, ‘textual critic’? So what does a critic do? He criticizes. What does he criticize? In this case it is the text of the NT in Greek. But just what is he criticizing? A literary critic looks at things like style and choice of vocabulary; a commentator tries to decide what was the meaning intended by the author of the text. So what does a textual critic do? He attempts to reconstruct the original wording of a text—notice that he is assuming that the original wording is ‘lost’, in the sense that no one knows for sure what it is, or was. (Notice also that this places the critic above the text, to which I will return.) Textual criticism only exists for texts whose original wording is deemed to be ‘lost’. No one does textual criticism on today’s newspaper, or last week’s news magazine. No one even does textual criticism on the 1611 King James Version, since we still have printed copies thereof. Any and all arguments surrounding the KJV come under other headings; they are not textual criticism.

Anyone familiar with the terrain knows that for the last 150 years (at least) the academic world has been dominated by the notion that the original wording of the NT text is in fact ‘lost’. Just to illustrate, some 65 years ago Robert M. Grant wrote, “it is generally recognized that the original text of the Bible cannot be recovered”.¹ For a number of further references echoing that sentiment please see pages 3-4 of my *Identity IV*. Before attempting to rebut that fiction [canard?], as I believe, I will sketch a bit of relevant history.

A Bit of Relevant History

The discipline as we know it is basically a ‘child’ of Western Europe and its colonies; the Eastern Orthodox Churches have generally not been involved. (They have always known that the true Text lies within the Byzantine tradition.) In the year 1500 the Christianity of Western Europe was dominated by the Roman Catholic Church, whose pope claimed the exclusive right to interpret Scripture. That Scripture was the Latin Vulgate, which the laity was not allowed to read. Martin Luther’s 95 theses were posted in 1517. Was it mere chance that the first printed Greek Text of the NT was published the year before? As the Protestant Reformation advanced, it was declared that the authority of Scripture exceeded that of the

¹ R.M. Grant, “The Bible of Theophilus of Antioch”, *Journal of Biblical Literature*, LXVI (1947), 173. Notice the pessimism, it ‘cannot be recovered’. In that event, the critics are wasting their time, and ours. Surely, because we would have no way of knowing whether or not they have found it.